Chapter 6

O atovo – The sago palm

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(a) (b)

Figure 1: (a) *O atovo* – The sago palm, (b) *Vua atovo* – Sago palm nuts

(1)	***O atovo***	**The sago palm**
(2)	*O naono vai o atovo na nebaneba komana bata ni riori.*	The sago palm is planted.
(3)	*Ei kou o naono bona eve to vaa'ave riori bona maa inu teori.*	Because it is this palm that they use for thatching their houses.

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(4) *O atovo mee, be vua, a vua nae repaa kuu, ore paa pura komana vahaa.*
Also, when the sago palm bears nuts, (and) a nut falls down, then it grows by itself again.

(5) *Beve sun rova nana tea hatana, na pura vakis nana.*
Even when it is standing in the swamp, it still grows.



(a) (b)

Figure 2: (a) *A kisi atovo* – A bundle of sago palm leaves,
(b) *Huha atovo* – Sewing the thatch

(6) ***Kosi atovo***
Cutting off the leaves of the sago palm

(7) *Bean tau kosi o atovo, taba momohu toro paku an, ean toro tagava roho o atovo.*
When you are about to cut off the leaves of a sago palm, the first thing you must do, you must fell a sago palm.

(8) *Ean repaa mosi hapehape o atovo.*
Then you cut off the branches of the sago palm.

(9) *Ean repaa kosi amaa paka atovo kahi bono sinoo vaa tobina.*
Then you cut the sago palm leaves off the stalk in the middle.[1]

(10) *Murinae, ean repaa varomo nia maa paka atovo.*
After that, you stack up the sago palm leaves.

(11) *Bean varomo vakavara, ean repaa kisi vatataunun riori.*
When you have stacked them up, you tie them together.

(12) *Ean repaa taneo mana tea dee voosu amaa kisi atovo vo vaan.*
Then you eventually start carrying the bundles of sago palm leaves home to the village.

(13) *Bea kavara na maa kisi atovo tei vaan,*
When all the bundles of sago palm leaves are in the village,

(14) *ean repaa taneo tea siri sinoo,*
you start tearing off the bones,

(15) *o sinoo vaa tobina no paka atovo to siri noman.*
it is the bone in the middle of the sago palm leaf that you tear off (the midrib).

(16) *Bean siri vakavara a peha kisi atovo,*
When you have finished tearing off (the midribs of) one bundle of sago palm leaves,

(17) *ean repaa vaoromo vaha bana amaa paka atovo.*
you stack up the sago palm leaves again.

(18) *Murinae ean repaa kaku eve, a vaamatatopo vaa tea huha.*
After that you fold them in preparation for sewing the thatch.[2]

(19) ***O sikiri***
The midrib

(20) *Amaa sikiri to paa siri vuru an tea maa paka atovo,*
The midribs that you have earlier torn off the sago palm leaves,

(21) *eve to pasi huha atovo vahaa ni noman.*
they are what you will use for sewing the sago palm leaves, i.e. the thatch sheets.

(22) *Amaa sikiri bona mee, na veveo raara bona maa nou vaa burihina.*
These midribs we also use for sweeping the rubbish in the backyard.[3]

(23) ***O rom atovo***
The stem of the sago palm

(24) *O rom atovo na romrom riori, eori repaa kopakopaa bari.*
They cut the stem of the sago palm crosswise into logs, and then they cut them lengthwise.

(25) *Murinae eori repaa taraha varaaramun bona komanae bara toon nae,*
After that they shave their inside and their outside to make them smooth,

[1]Compare Chapter 5:109.
[2]See Chapter 17 for details.
[3]See Chapter 5:110.

(26)	*ahiki ta taba re tahi ribari.*	so that nothing would prick them.
(27)	*Beve kavara, eori repaa deedee voosu mana bari vo vaan*	When it is finished, they eventually carry them home to the village
(28)	*mene paku bono baranda na inu.*	for making the floor of the house.



Figure 3: *A inu gorogoroho* – A sleeping house (under construction)

(29)	***Vaa'ave na inu***	**Thatching the house**
(30)	*Eori paa huha vakavara vaevuru bona paka atovo vai to paa kosi vuru maori,*	They have already sewed all (the thatch sheets of) sago palm leaves that they had cut off earlier,
(31)	*matatopo vai tea vaa'ave bona inu.*	in preparation for thatching the house.
(32)	*Evehee beori mei rori tea vaa'ave toro rahi obai maa roho,*	But before they do the thatching, they must get calamus canes,[4]
(33)	*bara toro mosi maa roho ta maa naono vai to pasi sun riori beori tau vaa'ave.*	and cut the poles (for the scaffold) on which they will be standing when they are going to thatch the house.
(34)	*O dorana o naono pasi vaasun vori,*	They will put up four poles,

(35) *eori repaa vaobete vananata bono meho dorana beori kisi batari bari bono kara obai.*
and then they lay another four poles across, while tying them to the standing poles with the calamus string.

(36) *Eve a poka bona to pasi sun bata nom ori*
This is the scaffold on which they will stand,

(37) *beori vaa'ave batari.*
when they are doing the thatching.

(38) *Bea poka kavara, taneo vai tea vaa'ave.*
When the scaffold is finished, they start thatching.

(39) *A kukan gea dorana aba pasi sunu tea poka,*
Three or four people will stand of the scaffold,

(40) *bea meha kukan hee hiava bona vana atovo.*
while another three pass the thatch-sheets up to them.

(41) *A dorana aba vai gina to pasi kisi bata ni nom bona vana atovo tea varuvaru na inu.*
The four people on top (of the scaffold) are the ones that will tie the thatch sheets to the rafters of the house.[5]

(42) ***A huun no atovo o aniani***
The edible sago palm mash

(43) *A abana saka tagava pinopino haari bono atovo vai to pasi koro riori mene ani.*
The people do not carelessly fell the sago palm that they will carve out for eating (the sago).

(44) *Na tara rori bono atovo vai o vahuusu vua,*
They see a sago palm close to bearing nuts,

(45) *eori repaa tagava bari*
and then they fell it,

(46) *ei kou na nata vorien o atovo bona o mataa bara o manoto.*
because they know that this sago palm is good and ripe.

(47) *Beori tagava bari, eori repaa kopaa pete bari.*
When they have felled it, they cut it lengthwise.

(48) *Murinae eori repaa koro bari bara tasu vamuramuraka bata bari.*
After that they cut it out and mash it (i.e. what they have carved out).

(49) *Eori repaa garuhu bari ruene.*
Then they wash it in fresh water.

[4]See Chapter 11:44ff.
[5]See Chapter 16:25ff.

(50)	*Beori garuhu bari, ore paa posi batari bari vo tea maa nahu vai amaa beera ge pagete.*	When they have washed it, they squeeze the water out of the mash into large pots or buckets.
(51)	*O hum vai to ani riori pasi taviana vaavaha komana bata nom.*	The part that they eat gets separated.
(52)	*Beve raka ore paa kakaavoo.*	When it is dry, it becomes white.
(53)	***Moroko vagegeana***	**Conclusion**
(54)	*O atovo o mataa, a haihai teve a beera sana en teara to vigu inu ni rara o atovo.*	The sago palm is good; its help is very big for us who use the sago palm for building houses.